Recycled Stardust & Borrowed Energy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/43089981.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternative Universe – Aliens, Modern Etheria (She-Ra), Artist Catra (She-Ra), One Shot

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Waiting for My Spaceship to Come Back for Me

Collections:
Catradora AUs by n7punk

Stats:
Published: 2022-11-15 Words: 1,899 Chapters: 1/1

Recycled Stardust & Borrowed Energy
Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/43089981.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternative Universe – Aliens, Modern Etheria (She-Ra), Artist Catra (She-Ra), One Shot

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Waiting for My Spaceship to Come Back for Me

Collections:
Catradora AUs by n7punk

Stats:
Published: 2022-11-15 Words: 1,899 Chapters: 1/1

Recycled Stardust & Borrowed Energy

by n7punk

Summary

Catra always thought getting into a museum was her ultimate dream, but it turns out that like most things in her life, it comes with baggage she feels like she can never set aside to just be recognized for *her*.
(Vignette in the Greys-verse/Area 51 Catradora AU)

Notes

So this was unplanned and written in the last hour. The Greys is the fav fic of a friend who's sick, so I wrote this for them. Hope they enjoy, and the rest of y'all too <3
This is just a little one-shot addition, not part of the main series. Like, it's canon to it, but it doesn't have plot lmao
EDIT: I accidentally misclicked when posting this and put an archive warning on this that absolutely isn't part of the fic. Sorry for the confusion, I've fixed it now.

See the end of the work for more notes

You don't get to choose which one of your pieces ends up in a museum. A gallery, maybe, if you still own it or the donor has a selection and is willing to listen to you, but a museum? Catra gets the call from her agent when the exhibit is already done being curated.

They didn't choose her best piece. It's not her worst either. It's a fantastical depiction of the Whispering Woods through the eyes of childhood innocence she never felt like she had back then, but definitely did. She understands why they chose it, accepted it, whatever. It's the first ever museum exhibition of art from beyond Etheria. She might be Etherian at her heart, but she is still an alien, and she was also a crucial part of the initial negotiations with the wider galaxy. It makes sense for her to be a part of the exhibit.

If she could chose, it wouldn't be this painting. She prefers her abstract work. It would probably be the all-grey – all-red, whatever – painting that she made as a teenager, staring down the barrel of a public life for the first time. It feels thematic, and that piece has a special – not necessarily good, but special – place in her heart. She's is pretty sure that Angella has it now. It was hung in the President's house some time after she left it at Area 51, anyway, and Catra would bet Angella took it with her when she finally reached her term limit. Maybe it's still there, but either way the museum doesn't have access to it.

It still feels like the right choice, even if the choice doesn't exist.

"You're not excited?" Adora asks, leaning over the back of her chair so she can kiss the top of Catra's head. She only just got home from work and got the news. Catra tips her head back, flicking her ear in Adora's face, and is rewarded when Adora reaches for it, holding it in place so she can give it a few kisses and then starts rubbing at its base.

"No, I am. Getting into a museum is big, and it's an important exhibit even if it's temporary, it's just." Catra trails off, the disadvantage of

tilting her face up made clear now that she is looking into Adora's clear, worried eyes. From the floor, there's a soft thud as Melog makes their way over and nuzzles at her leg. Catra sighs, reaching down and petting them blindly. "It's alien art," she offers a bit helplessly. It's not bothering her that much, but it is what's keeping her from bouncing off the ceiling.

Adora frowns, her expression immediately turning sympathetic. She drops her arms down to circle them both loosely around Catra's shoulders, the closest thing to a hug they can get right now with Catra curled up in her napping chair, positioned directly in front of a window with great sun during the day. Catra leans her head to the side, resting it against Adora's arm and feeling some part of her immediately soothed by the touch of her wife.

"It's just a disappointment that I'm being displayed on that caveat – which isn't even *right* – and not on my own merits," Catra offers, something she kind of knew already but is only crystallizing in her mind as she speaks. If it had been any other exhibit, she would have squealed like Adora tends to when excited when she got the call. Instead she felt her heart lift and then a weird trip after. It's still good overall, she thinks, but this isn't the milestone she thought it would be.

"Yeah," Adora agrees, somewhat darkly. After a moment, she seems to rally, sending Catra a hopeful smile, even if there's still an edge of uncertainty to it. "But Catra, your work is amazing. I mean, we know there's trillions of people out in the galaxy now and they still chose you," Adora tries to assure. Catra nuzzles her arm, her heart warm. She has things she could say to that – she's the only alien *from* Etheria who's an artist, making her a pretty obvious choice – but Adora is trying to make her feel better, and she's even succeeding, so she lets her eyes slip closed and breathes in deep, filling her lungs with Adora's scent. It instantly relaxes her.

"Yeah. Guess it just means I still have something to reach for. One day I'll get into a modern art museum, all on my own," Catra replies. She's not an optimist – she wouldn't even describe Adora as one,

really, even if she is the more positive of the two of them – but she has become less pessimistic over the years. She doesnt know how she could stay so jaded when she is surrounded by such love – from Adora, from their friends, from their pseudo-parents – on a daily basis. The stress from being so alien fading as Etheria joins the larger galaxy helps too.

"And youll get there. Your work is the kind that will go down in history," Adora promises her, kissing her ear again. Catra huffs, partially laughing and partially flustered.

"You dont need to flatter me that much," Catra points out, opening her eyes to send Adora an exasperated look, though she's smiling. Adora smiles back, the tension gone from her face now that it's gone from *Catra*.

"Not flattery if it's true," she counters. "That's definitely not how it works, but Catra stretches up for a kiss instead of correcting her. Kissing Adora is better than most possible actions.

--

Catra stops in her tracks when she walks into the exhibit hall for the first time. Actually, she doesnt make it through the door. It's a preview event, so there arent that many people present – artists, donors, members of the museum's VIP group, and some selected influential figures – but she still blocks the path as she stares.

She has, since learning of the exhibit, sometimes felt honored and sometimes felt rankled by her inclusion. Honored for obvious reasons, but disquieted because she *isnt*. The problem is that she *is* an alien, it just doesnt cancel out the fact she's Etherian too and it feels like whoever put this exhibit together is trying to strip her of that – like they think her blood is more important than

spending her entire life here. Looking at the exhibit, she doesn't feel that way anymore. The doorway is wide with plenty of room for crowds to move in and out at once, and it perfectly frames the display wall just inside the hall.

The only thing on the wall is her painting. It's a large one, almost as tall as she is, and it is set close to the floor, with only a thin barrier around it to break the illusion that you're stepping right into the Whispering Woods. The wall it is on must be specially constructed, or at least modified, because it is exactly as tall as the painting, with only a matching sliver above it to offset where it is raised from the floor level. The wall is just wide enough to block out the rest of the hall from view as you look through the doorway, but when Adora eventually tightens her arm on Catra's waist and urges her to keep going, Catra sees it stops just beyond that.

She allows Adora to lead her in, around the wall into the exhibit proper, wordlessly. There's no other art on the wall leading in, or even on the side walls, until after you pass the small display wall. It's a barrier blocking off the exhibit from the rest of the museum, directing the pace at which you experience it, but it's also a *dramatic* .

Welcome to the Whispering Woods. Here is where we discovered a world beyond us. *Peace by*

"Are you alright?" Adora asks, in a low voice, as they finally step outside of the main flow of traffic and pause before a painting as if to inspect it. The hall is just beginning to fill and Catra was very much in the way while she was having her moment, but she thinks she was justified in it. She doesn't know how long she was frozen before they got enough looks that Adora gave in and decided to usher them forward. She would want Catra to experience that – Catra *did* get long enough to experience that – but she also would be more cognizant of things like her reputation and the important figures here tonight than Catra was in the moment. It was good she directed them forward, Catra is just still processing.

"Yeah," Catra assures, absently, looking back over her shoulder at the wall. It's painted a deep, dark blue, unobtrusive while also allowing the painting's natural colors to shine. It lets the painting have all the depth it wants, maybe even expanding across the entire wall in the view of especially enamored viewers, without belaboring the point by framing it in an expanse of green that might help with the immersion of stepping into the woods, but also would lessen the painting's impact.

"I wasn't expecting it to be so important to the framing of the exhibit," she finally replies, stepping closer and turning towards Adora to all but whisper the words into her neck. She doesn't want anyone to overhear, and she especially doesn't want them to think she's bragging. Adora pulls back enough to make eye contact and read her expression, gaze flickering over Catra's face, but her arm remains solid around Catra, keeping her close. After a moment, Adora seems to decide Catra's emotions are positive and her expression softens into a loving smile.

"Mm, I'm not surprised," she hums back, a little smug, but she tends to be that way when she talks about Catra's art, proud of her wife's accomplishments. Catra rolls her eyes and smacks Adora lightly with her tail. If they were in private, she would do it properly, but this is the best she can get away with here. It only makes Adora's smile transform into a grin. Catra's heart is still stuttery and Adora looking at her like that doesn't help it calm down.

She has been torn on the exhibit before, but it turns out the exhibit represents something she has always been: a gateway into the wider world. It isn't something she chose, like her art is, but it is a part of her identity. It isn't othering her like she feared. She's okay with it, and the exhibit is, from what she can see as they finally begin to walk through it, superbly displayed. The curator will be here somewhere and she will gladly praise them for their work curating a story in the hall, not to mention the selections they have made.

She still wants to be recognized for the things she loves – the things she chose – but this is a part of her too. It's almost touching. She

feels seen in a way she usually isn't by the general public. It's nice. One day she will walk into a gallery, see her work, and be overcome with pride, but today? Today her breath feels fragile in her chest in a good way that she rarely experiences.

It isn't what she imagined for her first museum exhibit, but it is kind of beautiful.

End Notes

Title from Spaceship by Kesha as always.
If I ever do write anything in this verse again, I guess I'll tack it onto this as another chapter/vignette, but I'm not planning on it. I just also wasn't planning on this :DL

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!